



Northbridge Community Alliance

Policy Brief: Food Access & Equity in Eastview

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Executive Summary

Food access disparities remain a documented concern in Eastview, where residents report limited proximity to full-service grocery stores and increased reliance on emergency food distribution. Based on Northbridge's program data and community engagement findings, the organization supports targeted policy and partnership strategies that improve food availability, affordability, and distribution coordination. This brief summarizes documented local conditions and outlines policy considerations aligned with Northbridge's 2025–2028 Strategic Plan.

Community Context

Eastview has been a priority focus area in Northbridge's strategic planning process due to elevated demand for food assistance and documented barriers to food access.

Findings from Northbridge's 2024 Community Needs Assessment indicate:

- 38% of surveyed Eastview households reported difficulty accessing affordable fresh produce within walking distance.
- 42% of pantry participants in Eastview cited transportation limitations as a barrier to consistent grocery access.
- 27% of respondents reported reducing meal size or skipping meals at least once in the previous month due to cost constraints.

These findings reflect self-reported survey data collected during Northbridge's 2024 planning cycle and do not represent a randomized population study.





Program Insights

Northbridge's Food Access Program data (2024 Annual Summary) indicates:

- A 16% year-over-year increase in Eastview household participation in pantry services.
- Increased demand during summer months when school-based meal programs are not in session.
- Higher utilization of culturally responsive food options when available.

While program participation trends suggest elevated need, Northbridge does not claim that pantry participation alone measures the full extent of food insecurity in Eastview.

Policy Considerations

Consistent with Strategic Priority 1: Improve Food Access and Nutrition Equity, Northbridge supports:

1. Expanded local food retail incentives to encourage grocery development in underserved neighborhoods.
2. Transportation support initiatives that improve access to full-service grocery stores.
3. Strengthened school and community referral coordination to ensure families are aware of available food resources.
4. Data-informed planning that integrates community survey findings into municipal food system discussions.

Northbridge's position is grounded in documented community feedback and program data. The organization does not assert that these policy considerations alone will eliminate food insecurity but supports them as components of a broader, multi-sector strategy.





Equity and Cultural Responsiveness

Northbridge recognizes that food access is not solely about availability but also cultural relevance and dignity in service delivery. Community feedback highlights the importance of:

- Multilingual communication about food resources
- Culturally appropriate food distribution options
- Consistent scheduling and clear eligibility information

Policy discussions should incorporate these lived-experience insights alongside quantitative indicators.

Evidence and Limitations

This brief draws upon:

- 2024 Community Needs Assessment Survey Results
- 2024 Food Access Program Participation Data
- Northbridge Strategic Plan 2025–2028

Survey data are self-reported and may not capture all residents experiencing food access challenges. Participation data reflect individuals who engaged with Northbridge programs and may not represent broader community conditions.

Northbridge does not claim causal impact between specific policy changes and observed participation trends without formal evaluation evidence.





Topics Outside Scope

This brief does not establish positions on:

- Statewide agricultural subsidy reform
- National nutrition policy legislation
- Federal tax policy changes

Northbridge's advocacy engagement remains focused on documented local needs and mission-aligned initiatives.

